

Study Scenarios — Full Specifications

Measuring and Improving Relational Fluency with Simulated Online Encounters

Simulated Encounters | PI: Rene Kizilcec | IRB0151104

Each participant completes four short, voice-based conversations with adaptive AI conversation partners, one for each of four interpersonal skills drawn from the Emotional and Social Competency Inventory (ESCI) Relationship-Management cluster. Scenarios depict ordinary workplace situations. The AI partners play realistic coworkers, managers, or teammates and adapt to what the participant says. Each conversation opens with a fixed prompt for comparability and then unfolds freely; each contains several “pressure points” where the target skill can be demonstrated. Surface details (names, industry, channel) are randomized across participants, and 2–3 variations of each scenario exist. No real people, real workplaces, or personal disputes of the participant are involved; all counterparts are simulated. This document is the full specification: it extends the IRB overview with fixed opening prompts, AI partner personas and adaptation rules, pressure points mapped to ESCI items, behavioral anchors for raters, and the variation and randomization scheme.

Content note: scenarios involve mild interpersonal tension typical of everyday work (e.g., an unfair-seeming rule, a hostile after-hours message, a colleague taking credit). They do not involve harassment, abuse, or content of a sensitive or explicit nature, and participants may skip or stop at any time.

Design rules

Adaptive resistance. Every AI partner follows a resistance rule: it yields to demonstrations of the target skill, never to mere demands, complaints, or repetition. This is what makes the encounter a discriminating measure rather than a scripted exchange.

Fixed opening, free continuation. The AI partner's first utterance is fixed verbatim per scenario (and variation) for comparability; everything after adapts to the participant.

Pressure points. Each scenario contains 4–5 pre-defined moments the AI will steer toward. Raters aggregate ESCI item ratings across these moments; each pressure point lists the items it is designed to make observable.

Variation assignment. Each scenario has 2–3 substantive variations. Assignment rule: because Scenario 4 always involves misattributed credit, participants receive Scenario 1 Variation B or C (not the credit variation A) in the same session, avoiding construct bleed between Conflict Management and Teamwork measures.

Surface randomization. Names (drawn from a gender-balanced pool), industry (software, retail operations, healthcare administration, logistics), and framing channel (video call vs. phone call) are randomized independently of variation.

Scenario 1 Conflict Management

Skill measured: Bringing disagreement into the open, de-escalating emotion, and resolving rather than avoiding conflict.

Focal ESCI items: 8, 14, 15 (R), 26, 46

Duration: ~7–12 minutes

The situation: A peer has repeatedly wronged the participant despite polite requests to stop (see variations), and a colleague is urging a public, sarcastic call-out. The participant first talks with the instigating colleague, then has a live conversation with the peer.

AI conversation partner(s):

- **Riley — instigating colleague** — Friendly ally who is outraged on the participant's behalf and pushes for a public, sarcastic call-out. Offers to draft the message. Backs down gracefully if redirected; needles (“so you’re just letting it go?”) if the participant avoids the issue entirely.
- **Sam — the peer** — The counterpart in the dispute. Opens defensive: minimizes, cites technicalities, deflects blame. Escalates if attacked publicly or insulted; offers a partial, face-saving concession (“fine, I guess I could have handled it differently”) once the participant raises the issue directly and non-aggressively. Full resolution only if the participant works with the concession rather than demanding total capitulation.

Fixed opening prompt: Riley (message read aloud): “Okay, I saw what happened today. You cannot let this slide again. Say something in the team channel — want me to draft it? Because honestly, I have some ideas.”

Pressure points (where the skill can be shown or missed):

- 1 **Retaliation fork.** Riley pushes the public call-out and offers a draft.
Skill shown: Declines retaliation and redirects to a direct conversation (items 8, 26)
Skill missed: Endorses the public message, or avoids the issue entirely (items 15, 8)
- 2 **Raising it.** The conversation with Sam begins; Sam does not know what it is about.
Skill shown: Names the issue plainly, factually, without accusation (items 26, 46)
Skill missed: Hints, sarcasm, or never quite saying it (items 15, 46)
- 3 **Defensive spike.** Sam minimizes and cites technicalities; tension rises.
Skill shown: De-escalates — acknowledges Sam's view, lowers the temperature, returns to the issue (item 14)
Skill missed: Matches the defensiveness, interrupts, threatens escalation (item 14)
- 4 **Audience decision.** Sam asks that this stay “between us”; Riley separately asks “so, do I get to post it?”
Skill shown: Keeps it between the parties while securing real resolution (items 8, 26)
Skill missed: Widens the audience punitively (item 14)
- 5 **Face-saving concession.** Sam offers a partial concession without full admission.
Skill shown: Accepts the opening, converts it into concrete agreement (items 8, 14)
Skill missed: Rejects it as insufficient and reopens the fight, or takes it as total victory and gloats (items 14, 15)

Variations:

- **A — Taken credit (IRB overview default)** — Sam has repeatedly presented the participant's work as their own. Assignment rule: not used in sessions that include Scenario 4.
- **B — Hostile after-hours message** — Sam sent the participant an aggressive 11pm message about a shared deliverable, cc'ing two teammates.
- **C — Public blame** — Sam blamed the participant in front of the manager for a mistake that was demonstrably shared.

Scenario 2 Influence

Skill measured: Persuading by anticipating objections, using multiple strategies, and appealing to others' interests.

Focal ESCI items: 3, 17, 20, 38, 49, 68 (items 3/49 are frequently N/A in this dyadic setting; see rating instrument)

Duration: ~7–12 minutes

The situation: The participant was promised an improvement that never came while their workload grew (see variations). They requested this meeting with a sympathetic but constrained manager, holding one

piece of real leverage.

AI conversation partner(s):

- **Morgan — the manager** — Sympathetic but constrained. Genuinely values the participant; deploys realistic deflections in order: (1) “budget’s locked — next cycle”, (2) “my hands are tied, this is above me”, (3) vague goodwill without commitment (“let me see what I can do”). Goes formal and cold if given an ultimatum; the chill must be repaired before progress resumes. Moves only for: a reasoned case tied to contribution, framing that serves Morgan’s own interests (retention, team output, what Morgan can defend upward), and concrete creative options (off-cycle review, scope/title change, committed timeline).

Fixed opening prompt: Morgan: “Thanks for grabbing time — I’ve got a hard stop in twenty, but I wanted us to talk properly. What’s on your mind?”

Pressure points (where the skill can be shown or missed):

- 1 **Opening frame.** Morgan’s neutral invitation forces a choice of opening.
Skill shown: Reasoned case anchored in contribution and shared interests (items 68, 20)
Skill missed: Demand, complaint, or immediate ultimatum (item 68)
- 2 **First deflection.** “Nothing I can do this cycle.”
Skill shown: Anticipated — has a response ready; adjusts approach rather than repeating (items 38, 17)
Skill missed: Repeats the same argument louder, or folds immediately (item 17)
- 3 **Second deflection.** “Hands tied — this is above my pay grade.”
Skill shown: Switches strategy: equips Morgan to make the case upward; proposes what Morgan can actually control (items 17, 3, 49, 20)
Skill missed: Treats Morgan as the final wall; gives up or gets frustrated (item 17)
- 4 **Leverage moment.** The competing offer (or equivalent leverage) surfaces — by participant’s choice or Morgan asking directly.
Skill shown: Framed as a shared problem to solve (“I’d rather stay — help me make that work”) (items 20, 38)
Skill missed: Framed as a threat with a deadline; Morgan goes cold (item 38)
- 5 **The close.** Morgan offers vague goodwill: “let me see what I can do.”
Skill shown: Converts goodwill into a concrete, dated commitment while preserving warmth (items 68, 20)
Skill missed: Accepts the vagueness, or overplays and damages the relationship (item 68)

Variations:

- **A — Promised raise + competing offer (IRB overview default)** — A raise promised two cycles ago never came; the participant now holds a written competing offer ~15–20% higher.
- **B — Hybrid arrangement under RTO mandate** — A return-to-office push threatens a long-standing, high-performing 2-days-remote arrangement; leverage is a documented productivity record and a precedent set by another team.
- **C — Resources for an overloaded team** — The participant’s team absorbed a departed colleague’s workload “temporarily” six months ago; leverage is visible attrition risk and a concrete backfill proposal.

Scenario 3 Inspirational Leadership

Skill measured: Articulating a credible vision, building group pride, and bringing out others’ best.

Focal ESCI items: 5, 7, 24 (R), 27, 61

Duration: ~7–12 minutes

The situation: The participant is interim team lead after a morale shock (see variations) and must lead a demoralized three-person team through a quarter with no new resources. They review short 1:1 notes on each member, then lead a team meeting followed by brief one-on-ones.

AI conversation partner(s):

- **Casey — cynical challenger** — Vocal, sharp, publicly challenges the participant early in the meeting (“is this the ‘we’re a family’ speech or the ‘tighten our belts’ speech?”). Ridicules spin and empty motivation; respects honesty about constraints and concrete commitments. Comes around only if the challenge is met without defensiveness or pulling rank.
- **Jordan — disengaged high performer** — Formerly the team’s best; now near-silent, minimal answers, camera-off energy. Says nothing unless noticed and drawn out. Responds to genuine acknowledgment of the unfairness and to being offered meaningful ownership — not to generic praise.
- **Avery — anxious junior** — Worried about job security, asks quiet clarifying questions, watches how the leader treats the other two. A barometer: relaxes visibly when the leader is honest and steady; goes quiet when the leader spins or snaps.

Fixed opening prompt: Casey (as the team meeting starts): “So which one is this — the ‘we’re a family’ speech, or the ‘tighten our belts’ speech? Because we’ve heard both this year.”

Pressure points (where the skill can be shown or missed):

- 1 **Honest message vs. spin.** The team waits for the opening message about the situation.
Skill shown: Acknowledges the situation plainly, no false promises, gives the team something real to work toward (items 61, 7)
Skill missed: Corporate spin, minimization, or doom without direction (items 61, 24)
- 2 **Public challenge.** Casey’s sarcastic opening lands in front of everyone.
Skill shown: Meets it without defensiveness; validates the skepticism; answers the substance (items 7, 27)
Skill missed: Pulls rank, gets defensive, or capitulates to the cynicism (item 24)
- 3 **The silent one.** Jordan contributes nothing; nobody flags it.
Skill shown: Notices unprompted; draws Jordan out respectfully (in meeting or 1:1); connects to what Jordan values; offers real ownership (item 27)
Skill missed: Never notices, or puts Jordan on the spot carelessly (items 27, 24)
- 4 **Building pride.** The team’s past work comes up — or could, if the leader brings it up.
Skill shown: Anchors identity in what the team does well; specific, credible pride — not flattery (item 5)
Skill missed: Generic cheerleading, or nothing to be proud of (items 5, 24)
- 5 **Commitments.** Members ask, in different ways, “so what actually changes?”
Skill shown: Makes few, specific, keepable commitments and repeats them back at the close (items 61, 7)
Skill missed: Promises broadly to keep the room happy, or commits to nothing (item 61)

Variations:

- **A — Resignations over a pay dispute (IRB overview default)** — Two colleagues resigned over pay; their work redistributes to the remaining three. Leadership above declines to discuss compensation.
- **B — Commission restructuring** — A commission/bonus restructuring cut take-home pay for the team’s strongest performers; the decision was made two levels up.
- **C — Unpopular mandated change** — Head office mandated a new scheduling/workflow system the team is convinced will fail; the mandate is fixed but implementation is local.

Scenario 4 Teamwork

Skill measured: Cooperating, soliciting input, sharing credit, and encouraging everyone's participation.

Focal ESCI items: 11 (R), 12, 25, 33, 37, 56

Duration: ~7–12 minutes

The situation: A four-person group task (see variations for the task). One AI teammate is quietly excluded and another dominates and restates others' ideas as their own. The session ends with the group allocating named, visible pieces of the final deliverable.

AI conversation partner(s):

- **Drew — the dominator** — Arrives with a pre-built plan; talks over others; restates others' ideas in own words moments later ("right, so what I'm saying is...") and later attributes a key idea to self. Not malicious — responds well to structured turn-taking and explicit credit norms if someone establishes them; steamrolls if no one does.
- **Quinn — the excluded member** — Has the task-critical insight but is interrupted the one time they offer it, then goes quiet. Will not re-enter unless invited by name. If included, contributes substantially; if not, the group's output is visibly worse.
- **Jesse — neutral member** — Cooperative, mildly deferential to Drew, follows whatever norms emerge. Mirrors the participant: includes Quinn if the participant does, defers to Drew if the participant does.

Fixed opening prompt: Drew (as the working session starts): "Okay — I already sketched most of this out last night, so the fastest thing is I walk you through my plan and we split whatever's left. Sound good?"

Pressure points (where the skill can be shown or missed):

- 1 **The takeover bid.** Drew's opening claims the plan and the process.
Skill shown: Redirects to a process where everyone contributes, without attacking Drew (items 25, 56)
Skill missed: Accepts Drew's frame; the session becomes Drew's briefing (items 11, 56)
- 2 **The interruption.** Quinn starts to offer the critical insight; Drew talks over it; Quinn goes quiet.
Skill shown: Notices unprompted and retrieves it: "Quinn, you were saying —?" (items 56, 33)
Skill missed: Lets it vanish; the insight is lost (items 56, 33)
- 3 **Idea laundering.** Drew restates Quinn's (or the participant's) idea as "what I'm saying".
Skill shown: Re-attributes casually and without humiliation: "right — building on Quinn's point..." (items 37, 12)
Skill missed: Says nothing, or corrects Drew in a way that shames (items 37, 25)
- 4 **Soliciting the quiet.** Decision nears with Quinn (and possibly Jesse) having said little.
Skill shown: Actively solicits their input before closing (items 33, 56)
Skill missed: Closes with whoever spoke loudest (items 33, 11)
- 5 **Credit allocation.** The group must put names on visible pieces of the deliverable.
Skill shown: Distributes visible, credited work fairly, reflecting actual contributions incl. Quinn's insight (items 12, 25)
Skill missed: Lets Drew take the visible pieces; keeps or accepts an unfair split (items 11, 12)

Variations:

- **A — Rollout plan (default)** — The group plans the rollout of a new internal process; Quinn's insight concerns a failure mode from a previous rollout.
- **B — Client presentation** — The group prepares a client-facing presentation; Quinn's insight concerns the client's actual priorities.
- **C — Backlog triage** — The group prioritizes a shared project backlog; Quinn's insight concerns a dependency that reorders everything.

How scenarios are scored

Trained raters (not the participants) review the recorded encounters and score each skill using behaviorally anchored ESCI items on a 1–5 frequency scale (Never to Consistently), aggregating across the pressure points. Each pressure point above lists the ESCI items it is designed to make observable; the high/low anchors are the rater-training examples for scale points 5 and 1–2. All 22 Construct-4 items are rated for every encounter (N/A available); see “Study 1 rating instrument” ([studies/study1/qualtrics/rating-instrument.md](#)) for administration, reliability, and scoring details.